

ML-Based Surrogate for Ocean Carbon Sink Dynamics

Physics Reproduction, Validation & Meeting Brief

20-Credit Project — Comprehensive Progress Report

International Institute of Information Technology Bangalore (IIITB)

Student Aryan Vaghasiya

GitHub github.com/aryanvaghasiya

Reference Paper Sunny *et al.*, *Chaos* **33**, 103134 (2023)

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This document consolidates two phases of work: an initial SST reproduction (Phase 1) and a validated, improved pipeline with exact paper boundaries and a full Figure 4 ODE reproduction (Phase 2). It also serves as a pre-meeting brief, summarising talking points and anticipated cross-questions with model answers.

1 Project Objective & Context

Sunny et al. (2023) built a five-ocean conceptual box model to predict the temporal and spatial evolution of aqueous CO_2 concentration C_i and salinity S_i for the North Atlantic (NA), South Atlantic (SA), Southern Ocean (SO), Pacific (PO), and Indian Ocean (IO). The model is governed by a system of 15 coupled ODEs driven by two empirical inputs: linearised sea-surface temperature (SST) and the Keeling curve atmospheric CO_2 forcing.

The goal of this project is to:

1. Reproduce the physics model pipeline end-to-end in Python.
2. Generate a labelled dataset from the physics model output.
3. Train ML surrogates (LSTM, XGBoost, Random Forest, MLP).
4. Quantify where ML agrees with or departs from the physics model.

The current project phase covers objectives 1 and the beginning of 2. The full pipeline is:

Input		Output
COBE-2 SST (raw)	$\xrightarrow{\text{mask} + \text{fit}}$	Linear SST equations $T_i(t)$
Keeling Curve	$\xrightarrow{\text{fit}}$	$p_{\text{CO}_2}(t) = 0.18152t + 367.41$
Initial conditions (Table I)	$\xrightarrow{\text{ODE solve}}$	$C_i(t), N_i(t), S_i(t)$
ODE output	$\xrightarrow{\text{ML}}$	Surrogate models

2 Phase-by-Phase Progress

The project has progressed through two iterative phases. Phase 1 established the baseline reproduction; Phase 2 corrected boundary definitions and validated the downstream ODE solver.

2.1 Phase 1 — Initial SST Reproduction (Baseline)

Phase 1 Summary

Reproduced ocean basin SST time series using approximate lat/lon masks and fitted linear trend equations for all five basins. Confirmed qualitative behaviour matches the paper.

What was done

- Downloaded COBE-2 SST (`sst.mon.mean.nc`); extracted 228 months from January 2000 to December 2018.
- Applied approximate rectangular masks for the five ocean basins.
- Computed per-basin spatial-mean monthly SST.
- Fitted $T_i(t) = a_i t + b_i$ via scikit-learn `LinearRegression`.
- Verified qualitative behaviour: SO coldest, IO/PO warmest, annual oscillations visible.

Phase 1 ocean masks (approximate)

Basin	Lat	Lon
NA	$> 0^\circ$	$280^\circ\text{--}360^\circ$
SA	$\leq 0^\circ$	$280^\circ\text{--}360^\circ$
SO	$\leq -50^\circ$	all
IO	$> -50^\circ$	$20^\circ\text{--}120^\circ$
PO	$> -50^\circ$	$120^\circ\text{--}280^\circ$

Phase 1 fitted SST equations (Kelvin)

$$T_{\text{NA}}(t) = +0.001356 t + 287.70 \text{ K}$$

$$T_{\text{SA}}(t) = +0.000024 t + 283.93 \text{ K}$$

$$T_{\text{SO}}(t) = -0.000100 t + 274.14 \text{ K}$$

$$T_{\text{IO}}(t) = +0.001462 t + 289.95 \text{ K}$$

$$T_{\text{PO}}(t) = +0.001740 t + 290.14 \text{ K}$$

Phase 1 limitations identified

- Atlantic mask truncated at 280°E , missing the eastern Atlantic sector ($0^\circ\text{--}20^\circ\text{E}$).
- Southern Ocean boundary at -50°S instead of the paper's -60°S .
- Drake Passage not set at 70°W (290°E) as stated in Appendix A.
- ODE solver not yet implemented; no downstream validation.

2.2 Phase 2 — Corrected Boundaries, ODE Validation & Figure 4 Reproduction

Phase 2 Summary

Fixed all five ocean masks to use the paper’s exact geographic boundaries. Refit SST equations, ran a three-case ODE diagnostic, reproduced Figure 4 ($C_i(t)$ for all basins), and quantified cross-case discrepancies at $< 0.007\%$ RMSE.

Corrected ocean masks (paper-exact)

Basin	Boundaries	Key improvement over Phase 1
NA	Lat $> 0^\circ$; Lon 290° – 360° and 0° – 20° E	Added 0° – 20° E sector (Atlantic wrap)
SA	$-60^\circ \leq \text{Lat} \leq 0^\circ$; Lon 290° – 360° and 0° – 20° E	Drake Passage at 290° E; SO boundary at 60° S
SO	Lat $\leq -60^\circ$	Corrected from -50° S to -60° S
PO	Lat $> -60^\circ$; Lon 140° – 290° E	Eastern boundary at 290° E (Tasman Sea)
IO	Lat $> -60^\circ$, $\leq$ equator+NH; Lon 20° – 140° E	Cape of Good Hope at 20° E, Tasman at 140° E

SST coupling into the ODE system

SST is not just a boundary condition—it enters the ODE at every integration step through three nonlinear physical functions:

(1) Schmidt number and gas-transfer velocity:

$$Sc_i(T_i) = 2116.8 - 136.5 T_i + 4.7353 T_i^2 - 0.092307 T_i^3 + 0.0007555 T_i^4 \quad (1)$$

$$\gamma_i(t) = \gamma_{660} \cdot \left(\frac{Sc_i(T_i(t))}{660} \right)^{-0.5}, \quad \gamma_{660} = 0.24 \langle u_{10}^2 \rangle \quad (2)$$

(2) CO₂ solubility constant K_0 (Weiss 1974):

$$\ln K_{0,i} = A_1 + A_2 \left(\frac{100}{T_i} \right) + A_3 \ln \left(\frac{T_i}{100} \right) + S_i \left[B_1 + B_2 \left(\frac{T_i}{100} \right) + B_3 \left(\frac{T_i}{100} \right)^2 \right] \quad (3)$$

(3) Air-sea CO₂ exchange:

$$\text{Flux}_i = \frac{\gamma_i A_i}{V_i} (K_{0,i} p_{\text{CO}_2}^{\text{atm}}(t) - C_i) \quad (4)$$

This means every $\sim 5\%$ error in SST propagates nonlinearly into γ_i and $K_{0,i}$ at every solver step.

3 Detailed Phase 1 vs Phase 2 Comparison

3.1 SST Slope Comparison: Both Phases vs. Paper

Basin	Paper [K/mo]	Phase 1 [K/mo]	Phase 2 [K/mo]	Ph2 Error [%]
NA	+0.001700	+0.001356	+0.001520	−10.6%
SA	−0.000150	+0.000024	+0.0000007	+100.5%
SO	−0.000560	−0.000100	−0.000187	+66.6%
PO	+0.001550	+0.001740	+0.000321	−79.3%
IO	+0.000260	+0.001462	+0.000548	+110.7%

Note: Large percentage errors in slope are expected because seasonal oscillations of 1.5–5 K over 18 years completely dominate decadal trends. The absolute intercepts match to within 0.03–5 K, and the downstream ODE is insensitive to these slope errors (see Section 4).

3.2 Intercept Comparison: Phase 2 vs. Paper

Basin	Paper [K]	Phase 2 [K]	Diff [K]
NA	291.90	286.84	−5.06
SA	290.30	288.31	−1.99
SO	272.29	272.26	−0.03
PO	292.88	291.56	−1.32
IO	291.57	289.91	−1.66

The Southern Ocean intercept matches to within 0.03 K — near-perfect. NA shows the largest intercept gap (−5.06 K), consistent with excluding the warmer subpolar gyre regions and the absence of an explicit Arctic Ocean box.

4 ODE Validation — Three-Case Diagnostic

To isolate error propagation, three diagnostic cases were run using a stiff Radau solver ($\text{rtol} = 10^{-6}$, $\text{atol} = 10^{-10}$) over $t \in [0, 228]$ months:

Case	Masks	SST equations
A	Approximate (Phase 1)	Phase 1 fitted equations
B	Paper-exact (Phase 2)	Phase 2 fitted equations
C	Paper-exact (Phase 2)	Exact paper Appendix D equations

4.1 Figure 4 Reproduction — CO₂ Trajectory Results

Basin	C_0	Case C	Case B	ΔC	RMSE (B–C)
	[mol/m ³]	[mol/m ³]	[mol/m ³]	[mol/m ³]	[mol/m ³]
NA	0.01413	0.015847	0.015848	+0.001717	5.49×10^{-7}
SA	0.01579	0.016597	0.016597	+0.000807	1.97×10^{-7}
SO	0.01400	0.017790	0.017791	+0.003791	3.09×10^{-8}
PO	0.01834	0.018099	0.018099	−0.000241	1.53×10^{-7}
IO	0.01671	0.014838	0.014839	−0.001872	1.70×10^{-7}

4.2 Key Validation Findings

1. **Southern Ocean dominance confirmed.** SO shows the largest net CO₂ uptake (+0.003791 mol/m³), more than double NA (+0.001717 mol/m³)—replicating the paper’s central claim.
2. **Correct basin hierarchy reproduced.**

$$\text{SO} \gg \text{NA} > \text{SA} > \text{PO} > \text{IO}$$

This matches the ordering in the paper’s Figure 4 inset exactly.

3. **ODE is robust to SST fitting errors.** The discrepancy between Case B (our fitted SST) and Case C (paper’s exact SST equations) is $< 0.007\%$ across all five basins (RMSE $\sim \mathcal{O}(10^{-7})$ mol/m³). This proves the thermodynamic solubility mechanism (K_0) is the dominant stabilising force, not the slope of the SST trend.
4. **PO and IO act as net CO₂ sources** in the 2000–2018 window ($\Delta C < 0$), consistent with the paper’s finding.

5 Deliverables Produced

File	Contents
sst_monthly_paper_boundaries.K.csv	28-month per-basin SST in Kelvin (corrected masks)
sst_trend_comparison.csv	Slope, intercept, R ² , RMSE, % error vs. Appendix D
sst_actual_vs_trend.png	5-panel actual SST vs. linear fits
sst_basin_timeseries.png	Multi-basin SST overlay
figure4_co2_trajectory.png	Figure 4 reproduction (Cases A, B, C)
figure4_validation_metrics.csv	Final trajectory values, net ΔC , RMSE
figure5_salinity_evolution.png	Salinity trajectory $S_i(t)$